

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CROATIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around the fight for the Ombla spring above Dubrovnik — a hidden cave world and a city's drinking water, saved from the state power company by demanding a proper assessment under Europe's nature rules — and it names the tools you'll meet (the Natura 2000 protections, the environmental-impact assessment, the financier's exit, the citizens' initiative and referendum) in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

At the source of the **Ombla** spring — the very water Dubrovnik drinks — the national utility, **HEP**, planned an underground hydropower plant that would have flooded the **Vilina Cave–Ombla Spring** karst system, home to **sixty-eight cave species, fourteen of them found nowhere else on Earth**, and strained the city's drinking supply. The project rested on a **decade-old environmental study**, and its backers rushed to approve it before harder questions could be asked. Croatians asked them anyway. Environmental groups — **Zelena akcija**, the Croatian Friends of the Earth — together with a bank-watch network and the local **Sr■ je naš** citizens' initiative, challenged the outdated assessment and demanded a proper one under the European rules Croatia was joining. When that assessment showed the lasting damage to a **Natura 2000** protected site, the project's foundations gave way: in 2013 its main financier, a European development bank, **cancelled its €123 million loan**, and in 2015 Croatia's own **environment ministry refused the impact assessment**, ruling that the harm to the protected network could not be excluded even with mitigation. The plant was abandoned. Sixty-eight cave species, and a city's water, were saved.

Zelena akcija and the Sr■ je naš initiative drew on tools available to communities across Croatia, sharpened by the European rules it joined in 2013. The **Natura 2000 network** protects Europe's most important habitats, and harm to it can sink a project, as it sank the Ombla plant. A proper **environmental-impact assessment**, done under EU rules, forces a project's true harm into the open — demanding a real one, not a decade-old study, is a decisive move. The **financier's exit** is a sharp lever: a European development bank cancelled its €123 million Ombla loan when the harm became clear. The **local referendum** carries it — Sr■ je naš won 84 percent against a golf-and-villa resort on the plateau above Dubrovnik; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful and safe. And EU-standard **participation, access-to-information, and appeal rights** back it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. EU rules are **powerful but slow and technical**, so you need expertise and endurance. Developers **rush to approve projects on outdated studies** before the harder questions land. And the pressure to build energy, tourism, and coastal real estate is **strong on Croatia's beautiful and contested coast**. So aim for what these levers can deliver by forcing the truth into the open and using every European and democratic tool.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A hydropower plant or a coastal resort looks unstoppable when a state utility or big money is behind it, but it depends on approvals, assessments, and financing with weak points — and in the EU, a proper assessment and a Natura 2000 protection are chains that hold. A Croatian fight turns on the **Natura 2000 protections**; on a **proper environmental-impact assessment**; on the **financier's exit**; on the **citizens' initiative**; and on the **local referendum**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and forcing a real assessment that

exposed the harm to a protected site is the one that saved Ombla. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months — or years — on this, work out your real situation:

- **If it harms a Natura 2000 site, that can sink it** — the damage to the Vilina Cave network doomed the Ombla plant.
- **If it rests on an outdated or dishonest study, demand a proper assessment** — a real EIA under EU rules exposed Ombla's true harm.
- **If it has a European financier, that's a sharp lever** — a development bank cancelled its €123 million Ombla loan.
- **If it's a local project, a citizens' initiative and referendum can stop it** — Sr[■] je naš won 84 percent against the resort.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **force a project's true harm into the open through a proper EU assessment and the Natura 2000 test**, and **use every European and democratic tool — the financier's exit, the citizens' initiative, the referendum, the appeal** — to make the truth impossible to build past.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and where its weak points are.

Who Actually Decides

Big projects involve a **state utility** like HEP or private developers, and the **government** and its **environment ministry**, which grants or refuses the impact assessment. But Croatia is in the **European Union**, so the **Natura 2000 network** protects key habitats, a **proper environmental-impact assessment** under EU rules is required, and EU-standard **participation and appeal** rights apply. **Financiers** — often European development banks — can be made to withdraw. And **municipalities, citizens' initiatives**, and **local referendums** hold real power. Know which of these lie between the project and the ground.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The assessment. A project needs an approved environmental-impact assessment. *Your opening — the decisive one:* demand a proper, honest one under EU rules, not an outdated study.

The Natura 2000 test. *Your opening:* the harm to a protected site, which can sink a project.

The financing. *Your opening:* a European financier that can be made to withdraw, as one withdrew from Ombla.

The local decision. *Your opening:* a citizens' initiative and a referendum, as at Sr[■].

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **What the project needs to proceed** — an impact assessment, permits, financing — because each is a stage you can contest. **What it would harm** — the Natura 2000 site, the water, the karst, the coast — the truth a proper assessment forces open. **Who finances it** — often a European development bank, which can be made to withdraw, as one cancelled the €123 million Ombla loan.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment ministry** grants or refuses the impact assessment. The **Natura 2000 network** and EU nature law protect key habitats. **European financiers** can be made to withdraw. **EU institutions** stand behind the rules. Croatia's **strong environmental groups** — Zelena akcija and others — and **bank-watch networks** supply the expertise. And **municipalities, citizens' initiatives, and referendums** — like Sr■ je naš — hold local power.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, in an EU member state where the tools are strong but slow and the pressure to build is real. What most moves them: whether a proper assessment exposes real harm, especially to a Natura 2000 site, and whether a financier or a local vote can be reached.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Demand a proper EIA under EU rules	35–60%	1–3 yr	low–mod	The true harm forced into the open (Ombla)
Enforce Natura 2000 protection	40–65%	1–3 yr	low–mod	Harm to a protected site sinks a project
Make a European financier withdraw	30–55%	1–2 yr	low	A loan cancelled (€123m at Ombla)
Citizens' initiative + referendum	35–60%	months–yr	low	A local project voted down (Sr■, 84%)
Participation + appeal rights	25–50%	months–yr	low–mod	A decision delayed or quashed
Everything together	45–70%	years	mod	A project abandoned (as Ombla was)
Against a rushed approval on old studies	25–50%	1–2 yr	mod	Slower — you must force the real assessment

The levers that move the needle most are a **proper EU environmental-impact assessment** and the **Natura 2000 test**, backed by the **financier's exit** and the **citizens' initiative and referendum**. Ombla shows the ceiling (a state utility's plant abandoned when a real assessment exposed the harm and the financier withdrew) and the honest floor (the tools are slow and technical, and developers rush approvals on outdated studies). So aim for a proper assessment, a Natura 2000 protection enforced, a loan cancelled, a permit refused, or a local project voted down — by forcing the truth into the open.

On cost: Croatia's EU-standard levers cost mainly organised, expert effort — the assessment challenge, the Natura 2000 case, the financier pressure, the referendum, the appeals are open to citizens and NGOs. The great strength is the EU's powerful nature law and its honest assessment requirement; the honest limit is that these are slow and technical, and rushed approvals on old studies must be forced back to the truth.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this assessment, this Natura 2000 site, this financier — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and what does it need to proceed? Name the project (a hydropower plant, a coastal resort), the utility or developer, and what it needs: an approved impact assessment, permits, financing — each a stage you can contest.

2. What would it harm — and is it Natura 2000? The **water, the karst, the habitat, the coast** — and, crucially, whether it harms a **Natura 2000** site, which can sink it, as the Vilina Cave harm sank Ombla.

3. What does its assessment rest on? Whether it rests on an **outdated or dishonest study** — as Ombla rested on a decade-old one — because **demanding a proper EIA under EU rules is your decisive move**.

4. Who finances it? Whether a **European development bank or financier** backs it, which can be made to withdraw, as one withdrew €123 million from Ombla.

5. Is there a local vote to win? Whether a **citizens' initiative and referendum** can decide it, as Sr[■] je naš won 84 percent against the resort.

What this looks like in real life. A state utility plans a plant that would flood a protected cave system and strain a city's water, on a decade-old study. The five questions yield: the plant and its need for an assessment, permits, and financing (the stages to contest); the harm to a Natura 2000 site (the sinking point); the outdated study (demand a real one); the European financier (make it withdraw); and, for a coastal scheme, a referendum to win. That's the Ombla pattern — force a proper assessment, prove the Natura 2000 harm, and the foundations give way.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a campaign that forces the truth open and one that can't is proof — the honest assessment developers hoped to avoid. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the harm and the Natura 2000 test. Document the **harm to the habitat, the water, the karst** — and, above all, to any **Natura 2000** site — because harm to the protected network, shown honestly, can sink a project, as it sank Ombla.

Layer two: the assessment's weaknesses. Document what the project's **assessment rests on** — an outdated study, an unasked question — because demanding a proper EIA under EU rules is the decisive move.

Layer three: the financing and the vote. Get the **financing** (a European bank that can be made to withdraw) and map any **citizens' initiative or referendum**. Walking to the environment ministry, the financier, and the public with proof of Natura 2000 harm and a demand for an honest assessment is what saved Ombla.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The harm** — to the habitat, water, karst, coast — and whether it's a Natura 2000 site.
- **The assessment** — what it rests on, and where it's outdated or dishonest.
- **The financing** — the European bank or financier that can be made to withdraw.
- **The permits and process** — the stages to contest, the participation and appeal rights.

- **The local vote** — the citizens' initiative and referendum available.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a coalition of expert groups and a mobilised public gives you the power that saved Ombla and won Sr■. Build in four moves.

Root it in the water, the place, and the people. Ombla was Dubrovnik's own drinking water and a hidden cave world; Sr■ was the plateau above the old city. Root the effort in the place and what it means to the people who depend on it.

Bring in the expert groups and bank-watchers. Croatia's strong environmental organisations — Zelena akcija and others — and bank-watch networks supply the expertise to challenge an assessment, prove Natura 2000 harm, and press a financier. Bring them in early.

Use the EU tools and the local vote. Demand a **proper EIA**, prove the **Natura 2000** harm, press the **financier** to withdraw, use the **participation and appeal** rights, and — for a local project — run a **citizens' initiative and referendum**, as Sr■ je naš did.

Build to last. Ombla and Sr■ took years. Build clear roles, a good archive, ways to decide together, expert allies, and the endurance to see slow, technical EU processes through.

STEP 4: EU NATURE LAW, THE ASSESSMENT, THE FINANCIER & THE VOTE

Croatia's levers combine Europe's nature law, an honest assessment, the financier's exit, and the democratic vote.

The Natura 2000 Test and a Proper Assessment

The Ombla lever: force a **proper environmental-impact assessment** under EU rules, not an outdated study, and prove the **harm to a Natura 2000 site** — because harm to the protected network that cannot be excluded even with mitigation can sink a project, as it sank Ombla when the ministry refused the assessment in 2015. This is Croatia's most powerful, distinctive move.

The Financier's Exit

A sharp lever: a **European development bank or financier** can be made to withdraw when the harm is exposed, as one **cancelled its €123 million Ombla loan** in 2013. Press the money with the proven harm.

The Citizens' Initiative and the Local Referendum

For a local project, a **citizens' initiative** and a **referendum** can decide it — as **Sr■ je naš** won **84 percent** against the resort above Dubrovnik. Backed by the participation and appeal rights, this is a decisive local lever.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: these EU tools are powerful but **slow and technical**, so you need expertise and endurance; developers **rush approvals on outdated studies** before the hard questions land, so you must force the real assessment; and the pressure to build energy, tourism, and coastal real estate is strong. So use the levers — the assessment, the Natura 2000 test, the financier's exit, the referendum — and count a proper

assessment, a protection enforced, a loan cancelled, a permit refused, or a local project voted down as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Habitat becomes a legal barrier. Not "we love this cave" but *"this is a Natura 2000 site with fourteen species found nowhere else — the harm cannot be excluded,"* as at Ombla.

An old study becomes a demand for the truth. *"This rests on a decade-old study — EU law requires a proper, honest assessment now."*

Harm becomes a reason not to finance. *"No responsible European bank can fund the flooding of a protected cave system and a city's water,"* as one duly withdrew.

A resort becomes a question for the people. *"Our municipality can, and should, vote this down,"* as Sr■ did, 84 percent.

Match it to the venue: the Natura 2000 harm and the assessment to the environment ministry and the courts; the proven harm to the financier; the local case to the municipality and a referendum; the water and the cave world to the public.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Croatia, the media front pairs a technical case with a public one — the Natura 2000 harm and the honest assessment win the process, but a mobilised public forces the truth open and wins the vote, as at Ombla and Sr■.

Lead with the water and the hidden world, not procedure. Not "the impact assessment was outdated" but "they would flood a cave world of species found nowhere else, and strain the water Dubrovnik drinks, on a decade-old study." Use your strongest material: the drinking water, the unique cave species, the beloved plateau.

Work the public and the decision-makers. A mobilised public presses the ministry, the financier, and the local vote. Make it easy: clear expert evidence, striking images of the water, the caves, and the coast, and a clear ask (a proper assessment; protect the site; vote it down).

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — in a technical, EU-standard process, one exaggeration can cost credibility. And offer the honest, positive vision: a city's water and a hidden world kept, not just a project stopped.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Demanding a proper EIA (to the environment ministry).

Subject: [Project] needs a proper impact assessment.

"We submit that [project] rests on [an outdated/inadequate study] and requires a proper environmental-impact assessment under EU rules: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8B — Raising the Natura 2000 harm.

Subject: [Project] and a Natura 2000 site.

"We record that [project] would harm the Natura 2000 site at [place]: [species, water, specifics] — harm that cannot be excluded even with mitigation, as at Ombla. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — To the European financier.

Subject: Your funding of [project] and its protected-site harm.

"We write on [project], which your institution funds. It would harm [a Natura 2000 site / a city's water]: [specifics]. We ask you to withdraw, as a European bank withdrew from Ombla. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Appeal / court challenge (to a lawyer).

Subject: Challenge — [assessment/permit].

"We seek to challenge [project]'s [assessment/permit] under EU nature and assessment law: [grounds]. We ask your advice. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — For a citizens' initiative / referendum.

Subject: A local vote on [project].

"We ask the municipality to put [project] to a referendum, as Sr■ je naš did: [specifics]. [Contact.]"

8F — To the utility / developer.

Subject: Opposition to [project] at [place].

"We are the community and groups opposing [project], which would harm [a protected site / a city's water]. We will demand a proper assessment, press the financier, and — if local — seek a referendum. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: They would flood a cave world and a city's water on a decade-old study.

"[Project] would harm [a Natura 2000 cave system / Dubrovnik's water] on [an outdated study]. We can provide the science and the images. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the public.

Subject: Our water, our hidden world — let's protect them.

"[Project] threatens [our water / a protected cave world]. Ombla was saved and Sr■ voted down. Let's demand the truth and use every tool. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — though these fights run long — do these six things, in order:

1. **Check whether it harms a Natura 2000 site — that can sink it (8B).**
2. **Demand a proper EIA under EU rules, not an outdated study (8A).**
3. **Identify the European financier and press it to withdraw (8C).**
4. **Use the participation and appeal rights; challenge in court if needed (8D).**
5. **For a local project, push for a citizens' initiative and referendum (8E).**
6. **Rally the public around the water and the place (8G/8H).**

Even lean, those six force the truth open under EU law — the Ombla template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Croatia's field is mostly fair under EU law, but rushed approvals and strong build-pressure tilt it, so plan for it.

When approval is rushed on old studies. Developers hurry to approve on outdated studies before the hard questions land, as at Ombla. Don't let them: demand a proper EIA under EU rules, and the truth will out.

When the tools are slow and technical. EU nature law and assessment are powerful but demanding. Bring in expert groups — Zelena akcija and others — and bank-watchers early, and settle in for a long, technical fight.

When the pressure to build the coast is strong. Energy, tourism, and coastal real estate press hard on Croatia's coast. Lean on the Natura 2000 test, the honest assessment, the financier's exit, and the local referendum, which have beaten strong projects.

When it's a local project. Use your strongest local lever: a **citizens' initiative and referendum**, as Srđ je naš won 84 percent, backed by the EU assessment tools.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Croatia is an EU member with real institutions, but connected interests and rushed approvals in energy, tourism, and coastal real estate can still tilt a decision, so stay alert.

How to spot it. A project pushed on an outdated or dishonest study; an assessment treated as a formality; harm to a protected site waved through; benefits to a utility or a developer while a community's water or a protected world bears the cost.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **environment ministry**, the **Natura 2000** framework and **EU institutions**, the **courts and appeals bodies**, Croatia's **strong environmental groups and bank-watch networks**, a **free press**, and the **public and municipalities** — all real and, backed by EU law, effective.

How to fight it safely (and it is safe here). Document precisely and factually — the outdated study, the Natura 2000 harm, who benefits — and use Croatia's EU-standard channels: demand a proper assessment, invoke Natura 2000, press the financier, appeal, go to the courts, the press, and the public, and — if local — the referendum. In an EU member state, a well-evidenced case using EU nature law is powerful.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The Natura 2000 harm and the demand for a proper assessment force the truth open; the financier's exit starves the project; the participation and appeal rights press the process; the citizens' initiative and referendum can veto a local scheme; and a mobilised public carries it all. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and the EU processes are slow, so take the long view.

Early on (year 1): check for Natura 2000 harm; examine what the assessment rests on; identify the financier; bring in expert groups; begin building the public.

In the thick of it (years): demand a proper EIA; prove the Natura 2000 harm; press the financier to withdraw; use the appeal rights; run a referendum if apt.

The long haul (years): hold the line until a proper assessment exposes the harm and the foundations give way — as Ombla's did — for a protection enforced, a loan cancelled, a permit refused, or a project voted down.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Croatia can be done, even against the state power company — the Ombla plant, which would have flooded a cave world of species found nowhere else and strained Dubrovnik's water, was abandoned when Croatians demanded a proper assessment under EU rules, proved the harm to a Natura 2000 site, and its financier withdrew €123 million; and the same movement voted down a resort above the old city, 84 percent. Hold both truths. Croatia's distinctive power is real: as an EU member, it can use Europe's nature law — above all the Natura 2000 network and a proper, honest environmental-impact assessment — to force a project's true harm into the open, until its financier and its own government cannot proceed, backed by a citizens' initiative and a referendum. And the constraints are real: these tools are powerful but slow and technical, so you need expertise and endurance; developers rush approvals on outdated studies before the hard questions land; and the pressure to build energy, tourism, and coastal real estate is strong.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Check whether a project harms a Natura 2000 site — harm to the protected network, shown honestly, can sink it, as it sank Ombla. Demand a proper environmental-impact assessment under EU rules, not an outdated study, to force the true harm into the open. Identify the European financier and press it to withdraw with the proven harm, as one cancelled €123 million from Ombla. Use the participation and appeal rights, and the courts. And for a local project, run a citizens' initiative and a referendum, as Srđ je naš won 84 percent. Count a proper assessment, a protection enforced, a loan cancelled, a permit refused, and a local project voted down as wins. That is how Ombla was saved — Europe's nature law and an honest assessment, forcing the truth into the open. So can you.